

1 A JOINT RESOLUTION declaring Kentucky a Food is Medicine state and
2 directing state agencies to advance Food is Medicine initiatives.

3 WHEREAS, the United States spends \$4.5 trillion annually on health care with 90
4 percent of those expenditures covering care for people with chronic physical and mental
5 health conditions; and

6 WHEREAS, six in 10 Americans have at least one chronic disease and four in 10
7 have two or more chronic diseases; and

8 WHEREAS, diet-related physical conditions such as obesity impact 41.9 percent of
9 adults in the United States and result in \$173 billion annually in health care costs; and

10 WHEREAS, in Kentucky, 40.4 percent of adults have at least one chronic physical
11 disease such as diabetes or heart disease, which results in over \$29.4 billion in health care
12 expenses annually; and

13 WHEREAS, the incidence of chronic disease is higher in rural and other areas
14 underserved by health and community resources compared to better served areas which
15 intensifies population health disparities in the state; and

16 WHEREAS, some state pilot programs and national studies have demonstrated that
17 Food is Medicine intervention programs, especially when administered in clinical
18 settings, can prevent and improve health care outcomes for chronic diseases, thereby
19 reducing chronic disease rates and health care costs; and

20 WHEREAS, Kentucky has pioneered Food is Medicine efforts, including the
21 Kentucky Hospital Association's (KHA) partnership with the Kentucky Department of
22 Agriculture (KDA), to launch a dedicated initiative to integrate health care and
23 agriculture with the goal of making Kentucky citizens healthier by addressing poor diet,
24 food insecurity, and agriculture production barriers as well as health insurance
25 provisions, basic nutrition needs, and chronic disease management; and

26 WHEREAS, Kentucky hospitals, through the KHA and its members, are leading in
27 the Food is Medicine initiative by creating and implementing Food is Medicine programs

1 in clinical settings and employee care programs that track and monitor health outcomes;
2 and

3 WHEREAS, declaring Kentucky a Food is Medicine state will build on the
4 foundations of the KHA and the KDA partnership by fostering collaboration among
5 health care providers, private insurers, managed care organizations, state agencies, local
6 governments, and nonprofit organizations to expand initiatives using local farm products
7 in nutritional health interventions; and

8 WHEREAS, the Food is Medicine state declaration aligns with Kentucky's
9 commitment to improving population health, reducing health disparities, and promoting
10 preventive care as cost-effective strategies for long-term fiscal sustainability, particularly
11 amid Kentucky's ongoing battle against nutrition-sensitive chronic diseases; and

12 WHEREAS, the Kentucky Employees Health Plan (KEHP) expends \$2 billion
13 annually to provide health benefits to nearly 300,000 current and former public
14 employees and dependents; and

15 WHEREAS, KEHP has an established wellness rewards program that provides plan
16 members with incentives for intentional practices, habits, and initiatives that lead to
17 improved health outcomes and help reduce overall healthcare costs; and

18 WHEREAS, community supported agriculture (CSA) is a growing sector of
19 Kentucky's agricultural economy that allows farmers to offer shares of their seasonal
20 harvest directly to the public, providing farmers with predictable income and improved
21 farm viability, thereby leading to strengthened food systems and stronger rural
22 economies; and

23 WHEREAS, CSA programs improve public access to fresh, nutrient-dense foods
24 aligned with the dietary guidelines for Americans, support improved eating habits and
25 nutrition, help prevent chronic disease, and can reduce overall healthcare costs; and

26 WHEREAS, researchers examining the University of Kentucky's long-standing
27 CSA program reported improved dietary habits, reduced doctor's office and clinic visits,

1 and initial savings of \$2.47 in medical expenditures for every \$1 spent on the program;

2 WHEREAS, providing additional incentives to KEHP participants to consume
3 healthier, more nutrient-dense foods through CSA programs is an important first step to
4 improving the health of our state's workforce, a tool for supporting and growing
5 Kentucky's farm families and agricultural economy, and a pathway to reducing healthcare
6 costs for governmental employers across the Commonwealth;

7 NOW, THEREFORE,

8 ***Be it resolved by the General Assembly of the Commonwealth of Kentucky:***

9 ➔Section 1. The General Assembly hereby declares Kentucky to be a Food is
10 Medicine state to recognize the critical role of nutrition in preventing and managing
11 chronic diseases and to promote the use of local food products in health care systems.

12 ➔Section 2. State agencies are directed to advance Food is Medicine initiatives
13 by taking all appropriate actions, including but not limited to:

14 (1) Affirming the integration of nutrition as a core component of medical
15 treatment and public health policy;

16 (2) Supporting coordination with the Kentucky Hospital Association, the
17 Kentucky Department of Agriculture, and other relevant agencies and partners to pilot
18 medically tailored meals and produce prescriptions for high-risk populations;

19 (3) Forming public-private partnerships to support local food systems and
20 community-based food delivery; and

21 (4) Supporting evaluations to measure the health outcomes, cost savings, and
22 impacts of Food is Medicine initiatives.

23 ➔Section 3. (1) The Personnel Cabinet is hereby directed, in consultation
24 with the Kentucky Department of Agriculture, to integrate community supported
25 agriculture (CSA) purchases into the wellness rewards programs offered to public
26 employees and retirees who receive health insurance coverage through the Kentucky
27 Employees Health Plan (KEHP), for plan years 2027 and 2028.

1 (2) The Personnel Cabinet shall:

2 (a) Provide a process by which a KEHP plan participant can verify proof of their
3 purchase of a CSA product or contract;

4 (b) Determine a reward value or values in the KEHP wellness program for the
5 participant's purchase of a CSA product or contract;

6 (c) Develop a process to evaluate the participation rate of KEHP members
7 claiming wellness program rewards for CSA purchases; and

8 (d) Work collaboratively with the Kentucky Department of Agriculture to market
9 and provide information on CSA programs, including but not limited to preparing
10 information for distribution to plan participants and attending KEHP wellness fairs.

11 (3) The Personnel Cabinet may:

12 (a) Implement the wellness rewards program option required in this section
13 through a third-party administrator; and

14 (b) Consult with the third-party administrator or the Kentucky Department of
15 Agriculture to implement provisions of this section.

16 (4) The Personnel Cabinet shall implement this section for the wellness rewards
17 program in the KEHP 2027 plan year.

18 ➔Section 4. By July 1, 2028, for plan year 2027, and by July 1, 2029, for plan
19 year 2028, the Personnel Cabinet shall, in collaboration with the Kentucky Department of
20 Agriculture, submit a report to the Interim Joint Committees on State Government and
21 Appropriations and Revenue that includes but is not limited to:

22 (1) The total number of participants who submitted a CSA purchase for wellness
23 rewards points;

24 (2) The number of participants who are, or self-identify, as first-time purchasers
25 of a CSA product or contract as reported through survey responses;

26 (3) The number of participants who self-report dietary behavior changes as
27 reported through survey responses;

1 (4) The satisfaction level of participants who purchased a CSA product or
2 contract, including whether the participant would purchase a CSA product or contract in
3 the future, as reported through survey responses;

4 (5) Any data useful in determining potential reductions in KEHP healthcare costs;
5 and

6 (6) Options that would encourage the use of CSA purchases by KEHP
7 participants that align with improving health outcomes, reducing healthcare costs, and
8 providing more market viability for Kentucky farmers.